DEVORA RESEARCH & GUIDES

The Design System Playbook

A step-by-step framework for building a design system that survives contact with a real product team.

Devora

Sample document created for the Devora demo website.

1. Start with the problem, not the library

Most design systems fail for a boring reason: they were built to be admired, not used. Before you open a design tool, write down the three recurring problems the system must solve, for example inconsistent buttons across screens, slow handoff between design and engineering, or accessibility fixes that have to be repeated in every feature.

A useful rule of thumb: if the same UI pattern has been built three times by different people, it belongs in the system. If it has been built once, it does not.

When is the right time to start?

Earlier than most teams think. Around the third month of a fast-moving product, the cost of inconsistency starts to compound. Starting then keeps the system small, and keeps adoption easy because there is little legacy UI to migrate.

2. Tokens first, components second

Design tokens are the named decisions underneath your interface: colors, spacing, type sizes, radii, shadows and motion. Define these before any component. A component is just tokens arranged with intent, so getting the tokens right makes every later component cheaper.

Token group	Examples	Why it matters
Color	brand, surface, text, danger	Enables theming and dark mode without rewrites
Spacing	4, 8, 12, 16, 24, 32	Gives layouts a consistent rhythm
Type	display, heading, body, caption	Keeps hierarchy readable on every screen size
Radius and shadow	sm, md, lg	Makes surfaces feel like one product

Name tokens by purpose (**text-muted**), not by value (**gray-500**). Purpose names survive a rebrand; value names do not.

3. Build the smallest useful component set

Resist the urge to ship fifty components on day one. Start with the ten that appear on almost every screen, then grow only when a real feature needs something new.

- **Foundations:** button, input, select, checkbox, link
- **Structure:** card, modal, tabs, table
- **Feedback:** toast, inline error, loading skeleton

Every component needs five states

Default, hover, focus, disabled and error. Designing all five up front is the single biggest reducer of rework later, because engineers stop guessing what the missing states should look like.

Accessibility is part of the definition of done

Keyboard navigation, visible focus rings, and sufficient color contrast should be built into the component once, so every team that uses it inherits them for free. That is the strongest argument for a shared system.

4. Document for the person in a hurry

Documentation is a product. Most readers arrive mid-task and want a working example in under a minute. For each component, show: when to use it, when not to, a live example, the props or options, and the accessibility notes.

- Lead with a copy-pasteable example
- Show the wrong way next to the right way
- Keep a changelog so teams know what moved

5. Governance without bureaucracy

A system with no owner decays; a system with a committee stalls. A lightweight model works best: one small core team owns the foundations, and product teams contribute through a short, public proposal process.

Situation	Who decides	Target turnaround
Bug or small fix in an existing component	Any contributor, reviewed by the core team	1 to 2 days
New variant of an existing component	Core team	1 week
New component	Proposal, then core team review	2 weeks
Change to a token	Core team plus affected product leads	2 weeks, with migration plan

Measure adoption, not just output

Track the share of screens built from system components, the time from design approval to shipped UI, and the number of one-off overrides. If overrides climb, the system is missing something people genuinely need.

6. Rollout checklist

Step	Done when
Audit current UI	Duplicated patterns are listed and counted
Define tokens	Colors, spacing and type are named and published
Ship the first ten components	Used in at least one live feature
Publish documentation	A new teammate can build a screen without asking for help
Agree governance	Owners and proposal process are written down
Review after 90 days	Adoption metrics reviewed and backlog reprioritized

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